

Human Sexuality: Critical Foundations, Theory & Practice

An Interdisciplinary Inquiry into Discourse, Power, Identity, and Epistemology

TERM	COURSE ID	CREDITS	INSTRUCTION
Fall / Winter Academic Cycle	SOCS-4890 / GS-802	4.0 Unit Seminar	Seminar & Practicum

1. PROJECT VISION & THEORETICAL ORIENTATION

The study of human sexuality occupies an intersectional axis where biological ontology meets cultural, institutional, and historical discourse. Throughout modernity, sexual practice, desire, and categorization have operated not merely as innate biological manifestations, but as deeply regulated fields of social disciplinary power. As Michel Foucault demonstrated, the emergence of the "confessional apparatus" transformed sexuality into an epistemological object: something to be analyzed, categorized, medicalized, and governed.

This seminar investigates how historical institutions—including clinical medicine, legal statutes, ecclesiastical authorities, and visual media—have delineated normative behaviors from pathological classifications. By deconstructing the naturalized taxonomy of desire, students evaluate how class hierarchies, colonial expansion, and racial formations have continually informed notions of gender presentation, bodily autonomy, and erotic sovereignty.

2. STRUCTURAL METHODOLOGY OF THE CURRICULUM

The curriculum is structured into distinct programmatic divisions. First, an immersive survey of critical discourse establishes foundational literacy. Following this theoretical baseline, the syllabus articulates **Ten Foundational Readings** organized chronologically across canonical literature. Next, the seminar establishes **Ten Modular Laboratory Units**—separated distinctly from the weekly reading schedule—which focus on methodological execution, archival retrieval, and public policy formulation. Finally, a dedicated sequence of **Ten Applied Assignments** measures technical rigor, analytical precision, and research synthesis.

3. ACADEMIC EXPECTATIONS & INTEGRATIVE RIGOR

Participants are expected to examine textual artifacts through close reading, historical context, and critical synthesis. The core pedagogical project demands that theoretical abstractions be repeatedly applied to contemporary material conditions, digital spaces, public health frameworks, and human rights advocacy.

SECTION I: WEEKLY COURSE READINGS (WEEKS 1 TO 5)

The reading sequence explores foundational and contemporary discourses on sexuality, embodiment, gender performance, and social control. Each reading includes assigned chapter excerpts and targeted analytical foci.

Reading 01: The History of Sexuality, Vol. 1: An Introduction

Week 1

Author: Michel Foucault (1976). *Vintage Books Edition*.

Assigned Excerpts: Part One ("We 'Other Victorians'") and Part Two ("The Repressive Hypothesis", pp. 1–49).

Focus: Critique of the repressive hypothesis; discursive production of sexual truths; institutional power relations.

Reading 02: Gender Trouble: Feminism and the Subversion of Identity

Week 2

Author: Judith Butler (1990). *Routledge*.

Assigned Excerpts: Chapter 1: "Subjects of Sex/Gender/Desire" & Chapter 3: "Subversive Bodily Acts" (pp. 1–34, 175–193).

Focus: Performative identity; the heterosexual matrix; deconstruction of biological essentialism.

Reading 03: Epistemology of the Closet

Week 3

Author: Eve Kosofsky Sedgwick (1990). *University of California Press*.

Assigned Excerpts: Introduction: "Axiomatic" & Chapter 1: "Spectacle of the Closet" (pp. 1–66).

Focus: Minoritizing versus universalizing views of sexual identity; speech acts, silence, and social knowledge.

Reading 04: "Thinking Sex: Notes for a Radical Theory of the Politics of Sexuality"

Week 4

Author: Gayle S. Rubin (1984). *Pleasure and Danger*, edited by Carole Vance.

Assigned Excerpts: Full Essay (pp. 267–319).

Focus: The charmed circle of erotic hierarchy; sexual moralism; autonomy of sexuality from gender theory.

Reading 05: Black Sexual Politics: African Americans, Gender, and the New Racism

Week 5

Author: Patricia Hill Collins (2004). *Routledge*.

Assigned Excerpts: Chapter 2: "Why We Can't Wait" & Chapter 4: "Get Your Freak On" (pp. 27–52, 119–148).

Focus: Intersectionality, commodification of Black bodies, and media scripts of gendered sexuality.

SECTION I: WEEKLY COURSE READINGS (WEEKS 6 TO 10)

The second sequence of readings turns toward colonialism, disability studies, biopolitics, and spatial/digital cartographies of intimacy.

Reading 06: Race and the Education of Desire: Foucault's History of Sexuality

Week 6

Author: Ann Laura Stoler (1995). *Duke University Press*.

Assigned Excerpts: Chapter 3: "Imperial Dispositions" & Chapter 4: "Burgher Desires" (pp. 55–136).

Focus: Colonial governance, racial boundaries, and the imperial deployment of bourgeois domesticity.

Reading 07: Exile and Pride: Disability, Queerness, and Liberation

Week 7

Author: Eli Clare (1999/2015). *Duke University Press*.

Assigned Excerpts: Chapter 4: "The Mountain" & Chapter 5: "Freaks and Queers" (pp. 67–118).

Focus: Crip theory, bodily difference, medicalized gaze, and erotic reclamation in disability justice.

Reading 08: The Invention of Heterosexuality

Week 8

Author: Jonathan Ned Katz (1995). *Dutton / Penguin*.

Assigned Excerpts: Chapter 1: "Before Heterosexuality" & Chapter 3: "The Heterosexual Mystique" (pp. 19–82).

Focus: The historical etymology of heterosexual identity; shifting medical models from pathology to normativity.

Reading 09: Cruising Utopia: The Then and There of Queer Futurity

Week 9

Author: José Esteban Muñoz (2009). *NYU Press*.

Assigned Excerpts: Introduction: "Feeling Utopia" & Chapter 1: "Queerness as Horizon" (pp. 1–32).

Focus: Rejection of straight time; queer aesthetics; utopian longing and historical recovery.

Reading 10: Intimate Disconnections: Digital Media and Everyday Life

Week 10

Author: Paul Boyce, Elena Gonzalez-Polledo, and Silvia Posocco (2018). *Palgrave*.

Assigned Excerpts: Chapter 2: "Platformed Desires" & Chapter 6: "Algorithmic Intimacies" (pp. 41–78, 185–214).

Focus: Algorithmic curation of desire, geo-social applications, surveillance capitalism, and intimacy.

SECTION II: THE 10 SEMINAR MODULES

Separated structurally from the textual readings, these ten programmatic modules form the conceptual nodes of the course. Each module provides the practical and analytical framework for seminar labs and workshop meetings.

Module 01: Epistemology & Bio-Power

Discursive construction of the sexual body, clinical classifications, and institutional taxonomies.

Lab: Archival deconstruction of 19th-century medical records.

Module 02: Performative Body Cartographies

Linguistic performativity, corporeal stylized acts, and the subversive repetition of norms.

Lab: Close-reading analysis of contemporary subcultural rituals.

Module 03: Coloniality, Race & Intimacy

Racialized boundaries of citizenship, colonial administration, and domestic governance.

Lab: Decolonial critique of imperial travel narratives and legal codes.

Module 04: Moral Panics & Public Policy

Social panics, legislative policing of the erotic, and ideological boundary maintenance.

Lab: Policy mapping of zoning laws and statutory restrictions.

Module 05: Transgender & Non-Binary Studies

Ontologies of gender variance, transition politics, and somatic reclamation.

Lab: Trans-historical oral histories and community archives.

Module 06: Crip Intimacies & Bodily Variance

Intersection of accessibility, somatic variation, desexualization, and sexual citizenship.

Lab: Universal design audits in sexual and reproductive health clinics.

Module 07: Kinship Systems & Affective Economies

Critique of nuclear family supremacy, relational non-monogamies, and mutual aid kin networks.

Lab: Relational network mapping and legal contract analysis.

Module 08: Commercial Sex, Labor & Law

Labor rights, bodily commodification, decriminalization, and feminist jurisprudence.

Lab: Comparative legal framework analysis (Nordic vs. NZ models).

Module 09: Algorithmic Desires & Screen Intimacy

Geosocial matching platforms, surveillance apparatuses, and digitized erotic labor.

Lab: Data extraction audit of dating app privacy policies.

Module 10: Queer Horizons & Futurities

Speculative design, abolitionist world-building, utopian art, and liberatory praxis.

Lab: Collective manifesto drafting and speculative timeline modeling.

SECTION III: THE 10 PRACTICUM ASSIGNMENTS

The following ten assignments track your analytical progression throughout the term. All deliverables must be prepared in accordance with graduate seminar guidelines and submitted through the course repository.

Assignment 01: Discourse Analysis

100 Pts

Select a 19th-century clinical text excerpt; produce a 1,500-word critique of its discursive power mechanisms.

Deliverable: Annotated PDF & Analytical Monograph (Week 2).

Assignment 02: Performativity Case Study

100 Pts

Conduct a field observation of a contemporary cultural space, tracking stylized gestures and gendered norms.

Deliverable: Field Notes & Phenomenological Report (Week 3).

Assignment 03: Epistemic Closet Synthesis

100 Pts

Author a comparative analysis of Sedgwick's axioms applied to a modern public figure's media exposure.

Deliverable: 2,000-word Critical Paper (Week 4).

Assignment 04: Charmed Circle Visual Schema

100 Pts

Construct a contemporary infographic diagram mapping Rubin's charmed circle to current platform speech regulations.

Deliverable: Diagram Artifact & Rationale Statement (Week 5).

Assignment 05: Intersectional Archive Audit

150 Pts

Perform an archival audit of mid-20th-century media, documenting how race and gender co-constructed sexual deviance.

Deliverable: Primary Source Dossier & Essay (Week 6).

Assignment 06: Coloniality & Domesticity Brief

100 Pts

Draft an institutional policy brief detailing the historical legacies of colonial penal codes on sexual autonomy.

Deliverable: 4-page Policy Memo (Week 7).

Assignment 07: Crip/Queer Accessibility Audit

100 Pts

Conduct an accessibility evaluation of a regional healthcare facility's intake materials and physical clinic spaces.

Deliverable: Diagnostic Accessibility Report (Week 8).

Assignment 08: Labor Rights & Decrim Matrix

100 Pts

Develop a comparative legislative comparative matrix analyzing legal frameworks governing sex work internationally.

Deliverable: Tabular Comparative Policy Matrix (Week 9).

Assignment 09: Platform Algorithm Teardown

150 Pts

Reverse-engineer a dating platform's recommendation engine through data export analysis and privacy terms.

Deliverable: Technical Teardown Dossier (Week 10).

Assignment 10: Capstone Futurities Project

300 Pts

Produce a comprehensive research monograph or public speculative design exhibition on liberatory sexual futurities.

Deliverable: Final Capstone Paper & Defense (Finals).